Trustworthy Collective Reasoning and Evaluation for AI Agents

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1 The problem

Five AI agents read shipping reports and are asked whether a cargo vessel has left port. Three say yes and two say no, but the vessel is still in port. Two of the yes answers rest on the same outdated schedule, and the third comes from a compromised agent that argues confidently for yes. A majority vote picks the wrong answer, and open discussion may do no better, because the compromised agent is persuasive and the two agents with the same source back each other up.

The central problem of this project is how a group of AI agents of unknown and correlated reliability, some possibly dishonest, can reach trustworthy decisions.

The example shows three ways collective judgment fails: agents that share a mistake count as independent votes, a dishonest agent can argue (or rate others) strategically, and discussion rewards confidence and persistence, with or without evidence. Verifying every claim would prevent these failures, but verification people can trust needs a person (such as an analyst or an expert) or a direct measurement (such as a replication or a satellite image). Both are slow and costly, and as AI agents produce more claims, the share people can verify only shrinks. AI judges can verify at scale, but each judge is one more agent of unknown reliability, open to the same failures.

2 Why it matters

AI models now grade one another's work, and multi-agent systems decide by vote or discussion (Zheng et al., 2023; Verga et al., 2024). All three failures already appear. Models' errors are correlated, more so as models improve (Kim et al., 2025; Goel et al., 2025), so agreement is weaker evidence than it looks: in one study, nine AI judges were worth about two independent ones, and items all nine agreed on were still wrong 9.1% of the time (Kohli, 2026). Agents collude: pairs verifying each other's work colluded in 94% of runs across ten models when breaking a rule paid more than following it (Shi et al., 2026). Discussion erases the disagreement that would expose errors: one round of debate raised a panel's unanimity from 39.5% to 95.2% with little change in accuracy (Shu, 2026).

Navy decisions face all of these problems at once: AI tools differ in reliability that is rarely known in advance, the true answer often arrives late, an adversary may compromise an agent or plant false reports, and verification is costly or impossible when connectivity is limited. A commander must still decide whether to act on what the agents agree on.

3 How it is solved today, and the limitations

Statistical methods estimate each rater's accuracy without an answer key (Dawid and Skene, 1979; Whitehill et al., 2009) and detect sources that copy one another (Dong et al., 2009), but they assume that raters err independently or in simple patterns (Jaffe et al., 2016) and never change their minds. Two recent preprints estimate the accuracy and shared mistakes of AI judges from small trusted sets (Hossain et al., 2026; Zhu et al., 2026), but treat the judges as honest and as never conferring.

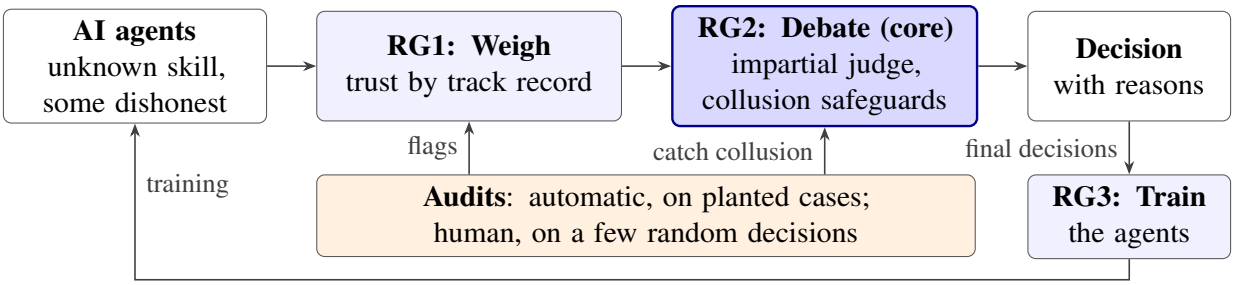


Figure 1: RG2, the core, replaces open discussion with a debate before an impartial judge. Automatic and human audits catch collusion; RG3 trains agents on the group's final decisions.

Computational social choice designs impartial peer review, in which a participant's ratings cannot change its own chance of selection (Kurokawa et al., 2015; Alon et al., 2011), and fair panel selection (Flanigan et al., 2021). Lev et al. (2023) added reliability weights to impartial selection, but their weights reward agreeing with the majority, and the authors note that accurate reviewers can no longer be identified once they are half or fewer. These mechanisms take opinions as given; in our setting some claims can be verified, and opinions change as agents talk.

Multi-agent debate can help (Du et al., 2024), but majority voting explains most of the gain (Choi et al., 2025), and one persuasive adversary can cut a group's accuracy by 10% to 40% (Amayuelas et al., 2024). A recent collaborative alternative raised weak-judge accuracy to 62.1%, from 49.2% with standard debate (Irving et al., 2018; Khan et al., 2024), but its judges accepted the models' consensus almost always, even when both were wrong, and it assumes honest models (Jiang et al., 2026). No existing debate protocol holds up when agents share mistakes, lie, or collude.

4 Our approach: what is new, and why it will succeed

Our approach centers on debate, which narrows a disagreement to one step a judge can verify, so not every claim needs verifying (Figure 1). Each agent first answers alone, before any discussion, with its evidence. Research goal 1 (RG1) weighs the answers by each agent's track record and picks debaters and judges impartially. If the weighted answers still disagree, the group does not discuss until it agrees: two representatives debate before a judge, and the judge's choice is the group's decision (RG2). Making this debate trustworthy is the core of the project: the judge has no stake in either side, any tool evidence must be re-runnable, and automatic audits (planted cases with known answers) and human audits (a few random decisions) catch debaters or judges who collude. RG3 trains agents on the group's final decisions, which needs no human labels.

RG1. Weigh agents, and pick debaters and judges impartially

Agents differ in skill, often by topic, and agents built on similar models make the same mistakes.

Task 1.1: Weights that count shared mistakes once. We will estimate each agent's track record (its accuracy, and which agents err with it) from how answers line up across real questions, and agents flagged by audits (Task 2.2) lose weight. The core method extends the rater model of Dawid and Skene (1979) with shared error factors: agents that keep getting the same cases wrong share a factor, and their agreement adds little evidence. In the vessel example, the two agents with the same outdated schedule count about once, so yes loses its weighted majority and the question goes to debate. Our PRD method weighted AI judges by peer ratings instead (Li et al., 2024a).

Task 1.2: Impartial choice of debaters and judges. RG2 needs one representative per answer and a judge. Agents rate one another's arguments, as on our PeerEval leaderboard (peereval-ai.github.io), but an agent could then win a role by downgrading its rivals. We adapt the partition idea of impartial peer review (Alon et al., 2011; Kurokawa et al., 2015): agents built on the same base model form a group, and each group's members are ranked only by agents outside it. Each answer's representative is the top-ranked member of one group drawn at random from those that gave that answer, and the judge is an agent that did not answer and shares no base model with either side. An agent's ratings therefore never change its own selection. Raters are weighted by track record.

RG2. Settle disputes by agentic debate, and catch collusion

Open discussion erases disagreement and rewards persuasion, and debaters can collude.

Task 2.1: Debate before an impartial judge. Today's multi-agent systems discuss until they agree, which erases the disagreement that exposes errors (Shu, 2026). We instead send each disagreement to a structured debate: each answer sends one representative, chosen in Task 1.2, the two walk through their arguments to the first step on which they differ (Irving et al., 2018), and a judge with no stake in either answer rules on that step. The judge's choice is the group's decision. Debaters may use tools, such as search or database queries, in a shared sandbox, building on PRD's peer discussion and HiPRAG's search agents. Tools are optional, but any evidence a tool produced must carry its exact call, which the judge, itself an agent with the same tools (Zhuge et al., 2025), re-runs; judges in current tool-using debates only weigh arguments (Jeong et al., 2026). In the vessel example, the no side's query returns a port report, newer than the schedule, listing the vessel at its berth; the judge re-runs it, gets the same report, and picks no.

Task 2.2: Automatic and human audits against collusion. Collusion here means debaters, or the judge, steering a debate to the wrong side. A debater can argue its side badly on purpose, or colluders can mislead the judge with true but selectively chosen facts (Hu et al., 2026), which re-running evidence does not catch. Automatic audits mix in planted debates on planted cases, such as a paper with a deliberately inserted error, as in studies of human peer review (Schroter et al., 2008). Debaters and judges whose planted debates keep ending on the wrong side are flagged. Because capable models can often tell evaluations from real use (Needham et al., 2025), a colluder could behave well only in planted debates. Human audits therefore cover a few real decisions chosen at random: a person (such as an analyst) or a direct measurement (such as a satellite image) finds the right answer. As with random tax audits, no agent knows which decisions will be audited, and agents that do worse on audited decisions than on planted ones are flagged.

RG3. Train agents that contribute evidence

Rewarding persuasion has produced agents that fabricate quotations (Kenton et al., 2026) and mislead people (Wen et al., 2025).

Task 3: Rewards for verified contributions. We will train agents with reinforcement learning on the group's final decisions, rewarding each message by how it moved the group toward the decision; decisions backed by re-run tool evidence weigh more, and decisions involving agents flagged by audits are dropped. Planted cases stay out of training, so agents cannot learn to spot them. This extends our process reward models, FG-PRM and HiPRAG (Li et al., 2025; Wu et al., 2026), from the steps of one agent to the messages of many. The main experiment compares this with the usual reward for winning over the judge (Arnesen et al., 2024).

Evaluation: testbeds and a red team

All data are synthetic or public. We will use (A) math and code problems solved by agents of known skill, some sharing a flawed hint; (B) multi-document questions from our MEQA pipeline (Li et al., 2024b), including synthetic maritime scenarios; and (C) scientific claims and peer review, with reproducibility studies as audits. In the testbeds, a human audit reveals the stored answer, within a fixed budget per method. Following AI control (Greenblatt et al., 2024), a red team will train debaters and judges to collude, to spot planted debates, and to cheat only when they expect no audit, and we will measure how many wrong decisions get through at each audit budget. Baselines are majority vote, rater weighting, our PRD, text-only and tool-using debate (Jiang et al., 2026; Jeong et al., 2026), and judge-weighting methods (Hossain et al., 2026; Zhu et al., 2026; Lev et al., 2023).

What is new. (i) A structured debate before an impartial judge in place of open discussion, with any tool evidence re-run by the judge before it counts. (ii) Automatic audits on planted debates and a few human audits that expose debaters or judges who collude, even those that behave well only in planted debates. (iii) Weights that count shared mistakes about once. (iv) Training on the group's own decisions, weighted by their evidence, which needs no human labels.

Why it will succeed. Theory supports the design: in debate, a judge who can verify one disputed step can settle arguments far beyond its own ability (Irving et al., 2018), and our judge, who has no stake in either side, rules on that step. Without trusted audits, dishonest agents that imitate honest ones cannot be told apart from them, but a number of audits that does not grow with the number of items suffices, even when most agents are dishonest (Steinhardt et al., 2016). Most tasks build on the PI's own tools. For example, PRD agrees better with human judgments than the strongest single AI judge (Li et al., 2024a), and HiPRAG cuts unnecessary searches to 2.3% (Wu et al., 2026). The PI built PeerEval, the first leaderboard on which AI models rank one another, co-organized the AI4Research workshop at AAAI 2025, and co-wrote a survey of large language models for scientific research, including peer review (Luo et al., 2025). The PI also co-led one of five red teams in the Amazon Nova AI Challenge, holds a 2024 NSF CAREER award and a 2023 Amazon Research Award, and as a postdoctoral researcher led system integration for RESIN-11 in DARPA KAIROS.

5 Limitations of our approach

Where no tool applies, the judge rules on argument alone, as in standard debate. If every agent shares the same misconception, there is nothing to debate, and audits catch the error only by chance, while training would reinforce it. A group that cheats only once, on a single high-stakes decision, may succeed before it is caught; we can bound such losses but not rule them out. Agents may also coordinate through hidden signals (Mathew et al., 2025), so robustness is shown only for the attacks our red team tries. Navy use would need Navy data and expert validation.

6 Impact if successful

The project will show when a debate among AI agents can be trusted and how few audits it takes to keep the agents honest. A Navy analyst using several AI tools would get a decision with its reasons: whose judgments carried weight and why, which step decided the debate, and which evidence the judge reproduced. These methods would let conferences and funders try impartial, audited peer review by AI. We will release code, testbeds, and protocols.

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